WORLD REHABILITATION ALLIANCE

FACT SHEET · EMERGENCIES WORKSTREAM

Rehabilitation and Earthquakes

Why rehabilitation must be part of every earthquake response — from preparedness through long-term recovery.

WHAT IS REHABILITATION IN EARTHQUAKES?

Earthquakes strike suddenly and can rapidly overwhelm health systems. These disasters cause large numbers of traumatic injuries such as fractures, amputations, crush injuries, spinal cord injuries, traumatic brain injuries, and sometimes, burns. Early rehabilitation — beginning as soon as possible after injury — is essential to prevent complications, reduce secondary impairments, shorten hospital stays and improve long-term outcomes. Rehabilitation also supports people with pre-existing health conditions whose access to essential services or assistive products may be disrupted during earthquakes, and in their aftermath.

CURRENT SITUATION

20.5M people affected by earthquakes worldwide in 2023	**~50%** of those who need rehabilitation services globally cannot access them	**2.6B** people globally live with a condition that could benefit from rehabilitation

- Many earthquake-related injuries result in musculoskeletal and neurological impairments requiring early and ongoing rehabilitation.
- Hospitals and rehabilitation facilities may be damaged or destroyed, further limiting access to rehabilitation for people with new injuries or needing routine care.
- Countries most vulnerable to earthquakes often have limited rehabilitation infrastructure, trained personnel and supply chains for assistive products.
- Persons with pre-existing disabilities are often disproportionately affected, facing increased risks during evacuation, barriers to emergency care, and interruptions in usual rehabilitation services. They are often late to be included in earthquake responses, or completely neglected.

ROLE OF REHABILITATION

Rehabilitation works alongside multi-disciplinary health professionals to maximise the impact of health responses to earthquakes, and optimise the long-term functioning outcomes of affected people.

Treatment in acute hospital settings

Rehabilitation professionals working in emergency and trauma units prevent complications and facilitate recovery — and these facilities face large increases in patients, requiring additional staff and supplies.

Hospital-to-home continuity

Rehabilitation shortens hospital stays, reduces pressure on acute services, and supports continuity of care across acute, sub-acute, and outpatient settings — including expansion of community-level services where inpatient capacity is overwhelmed.

Community reintegration

Rehabilitation helps protect and restore functioning by working with people to improve mobility, self-care, communication, and cognitive functions so people can return to school, work, and social participation.

Assistive products

Assistive products such as crutches, wheelchairs, orthoses, prostheses and communication aids are critical to functioning and independence after earthquakes but are often in short supply. Rehabilitation plays an important role in assessing needs for essential assistive products and advocating for adequate supply and appropriate distribution.

Psychosocial support

Many patients with injuries also have psychosocial support needs. Rehabilitation teams work alongside mental health professionals where available and integrate psychosocial support into their care.

ACTIONS NEEDED

Health systems should ensure rehabilitation systems, services and workers are integrated into earthquake preparedness, response and recovery, while ensuring the rights of persons with disabilities are protected at all stages.

Preparedness

- Integrate rehabilitation into health emergency preparedness and response planning at all levels (national, sub-national, service and facility).
- Ensure rehabilitation personnel understand and receive training for their roles in earthquake response.
- Take action to strengthen the resilience of rehabilitation services, facilities, and supply chains.
- Anticipate funding requirements and ensure funding for rehabilitation services responding to earthquakes is sustained for the duration of surges in demand.

Response

- Integrate rehabilitation professionals from the onset of earthquake responses to deliver rehabilitation interventions, establish continuity of care and support the overall health response.
- Ensure access to essential assistive products provided by trained personnel who can fit devices and train users.

Recovery

- Rebuild and strengthen rehabilitation services as part of "build back better" approaches so that rehabilitation becomes a core component of health system recovery and preparedness for future emergencies.
- Map vulnerable populations and ensure equitable access to rehabilitation in post-disaster recovery plans.

Rehabilitation is essential in earthquake response. It restores dignity, independence and participation — ensuring that people not only survive disasters but are supported to recover and rebuild their lives.

About the World Rehabilitation Alliance

The World Rehabilitation Alliance is a WHO-hosted global network of more than 100 member organisations advancing rehabilitation in health systems and the recognition of functioning as a dimension of population health. Anchored in the Rehabilitation 2030 Initiative and WHA Resolution 76.6 (2023), the Alliance convenes partners across health, policy, and the wider development community.